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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

CONTENTS

VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND THE OFFICIAL REPORT— [Col. 1]

STATEMENTS—

- (a) Volta Lake Boat Disaster — [Col. 16]
- (b) Making Entrepreneurship part of Ghana's Basic and SHS Academic Curricula — [Col. 30]
- (c) Statement on Fugu and the Ghanaian Heritage — [Col. 49]

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS—

Ministry of Roads and Highways — [Col. 67]

PAPERS—

- (a) Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Right to Information Commission for the Year 2024 — [Col. 88]
- (b) Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the Intestate Succession Bill, 2025 — [Col. 88]
- (c) Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025 — [Col. 88]

ADJOURNMENT— [Col. 94]

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Wednesday, 11th February, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 2:10 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE
CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there will be no Roll Call. We do not have a Message from His Excellency the President at the moment, neither do we have Formal Communication from the Speaker. I crave your indulgence to take the item numbered 5, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I hold in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 10th February, 2026 for correction.

Hon Members, page 1...7—

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you so much.

This is just a minor observation. For the sake of internal coherence, on the page numbered 7, the item numbered 5

(b), the way in which the word “Odododiodio” is written here, is different from the data of the House thus how the Member’s Constituency is written. So, if the Clerks-at-the-Table could take note and correct accordingly.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Clerks-at-the-Table should cross-check.

Mr Afriyie: On the item numbered 5, in line with the manner in which the *Votes and Proceedings* are often taken, one would notice that the sentence as written “...the staff and pupils of Gomoa Gyaman Senior High School”—I think that often, those at the senior high schools are referred to as students and so it should be captured as “staff and students” rather than the use of the word “pupils”.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, what I have here is the written as “staff and pupils of Covenant Presbyterian Basic School...” or are you talking about the item numbered c?

All right. Table, take note.

Yes, Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib?

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib: I was thinking that, because it is a basic school, the appropriate description should be “pupils” and not students.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, it is the item numbered c he is referring to.

Mr Shaib: All right, it is referring to the Senior High School, then that is correct.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 9...13—Yes Hon Member?

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would normally not raise issues from the Speaker's note, but a small observation pertains to the first paragraph of the page numbered 10 which reads;

“Ninth Parliament as the Constitution of the Republic of Ghana (Amendment) Bill 2025 and the sponsor later requested the addition of three Hon Members as co-sponsors...”

I heard him mention some names, as Mr Davis Ansah Opoku and others. So, I was thinking that if it would find favour with you, those names could have been captured as part of that, even though it would be in the *Hansard*—But if those names had been captured here, it would have been better.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Prof Kingsley Nyarko, what are you correcting?

Prof Nyarko: I am suggesting an addition of those names that he mentioned that are missing from here.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Prof Kingsley Nyarko, there are implications for it. So, what is here, should be taken to be correct.

Prof Nyarko: Then, on the second paragraph, the fifth line which reads;

“...whether the Bill complies with relevant Constitutional provisions. After the Committee unanimously confirmed the Bill's compliance with constitutional requirements...”

I suggest that the definite article “the” must be inserted to make it “the constitutional requirements.” Because if you leave that definite article, constitutional requirements could be any other constitutional requirement. So, I suggest that there should be the insertion of the article “the”, so that it reads “the constitutional requirements.”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: They are capturing what the Rt Hon Speaker said. It is his note that is being captured. That is why I asked, what you are correcting? Because if that is what he said and is captured correctly by the *Votes and Proceedings*—For instance, if our visitors give us their names in writing and same have been captured, in the way it is furnished in this particular House and it goes into the *Votes and Proceedings*, why should we be correcting that?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am not doubting what you are saying and I am not saying that what is captured here is a mistake. But there could be a genuine omission. I am just saying that we could cross-check. For all you know, there is a genuine omission.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Omission from the Table Office?

Prof Nyarko: At times it happens. You can ask Mr Camillo. At times there are omissions and other times, additions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, I will direct the Table to look at it.

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, my point is that Prof Kingsley Nyarko knows that this is a verbatim production of the Speaker's opinion. One can only make amendments to the last paragraph which reads;

“...the Rt Hon Speaker directed...”

So, this is a narrative. But with the verbatim production, unless one has a replica of what the statement the Speaker produced, then one can say that the definite article “the” is missing. Otherwise, the Table is accurate in capturing it the way it is.

2:20 p.m.

Prof Nyarko: I am saying that they should cross-check to be sure whether I am right or wrong. This is no injury, just a harmless observation.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Page 11, 13—Yes, Prof Kingsley Nyarko?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, normally what I observe in this House is that when a Question has been programmed and the

person whose name the Question stands in is not available to ask the Question, it is captured in the *Votes and Proceedings*. Yesterday, Hon Lawrence Agyinsam was not here to ask his Question, that is Question number 528, and I was thinking that it should find space in the *Order Paper* as a Question that was not asked.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, I was not in the Chair. What was the direction of the Speaker?

Prof Nyarko: In fact, the Speaker proceeded to the next Question.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if the Speaker proceeded to the next Question and he did not direct that the Question should be re-captured. Why are you faulting the *Votes and Proceedings*?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, at times, what I hear Speakers normally say is that because the Answers are provided, it should be considered as asked.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes.

Prof Nyarko: But in this case, no direction came from the Speaker. But the Question was not asked.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes. So, did you want the *Votes and Proceedings* to capture that the Member is absent and not available to answer the Question?

Prof Nyarko: No, what I have observed in this House is that when it happens, that the Question is not asked—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, on this note, what was the direction from the Speaker to be captured in the *Votes and Proceedings*?

Prof Nyarko: But the Question was not asked, so obviously it has to be—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, if there was no direction, there is nothing to be captured?

Prof Nyarko: So, what happened to the Question that was not asked?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, that is not for me to answer.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, no.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: It is for the Business Committee to take note that this Question has not been answered. Therefore, once there is no direction from the Speaker, do you want the *Votes and Proceedings* to capture it as if there was a direction from the Speaker?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I would not debate you on this issue because you are a colossus on this matter. But what I have seen in this House is that when a Question is not asked and the Hon Member is not available, normally it is captured in the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No, normally, what happens is that the Speakers can direct, and then the direction may take three or more forms. They will deem it to have been asked, and then the Answer published in the *Order Paper* should be transmitted to the

Hon Member. The Speaker can decide to be silenced. The Speaker can direct that once the Hon Member is not here to ask the Question, it is forfeited. But in this case, there was no direction on it. So, we leave it for the Business Committee. Once there is no direction on it, what are we expecting the *Votes and Proceedings* to capture, which has not been captured, for which we need to correct?

Prof Nyarko: You are the Speaker and I would not want to prolong this debate. So, I will yield to your final determination. Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by practice, the Hon Member whose Question is advertised and Answers provided, but for some reason the Question is not answered on the Floor, by our rules, you are supposed to take note. You are supposed to take note and approach the Table because the Answers are provided. The Answers will feature in the *Hansard*. So, you take note and have any issue, you come back with another Question at another time. Normally, the direction will come but once the direction did not come, it is up to the Member to take note of the Question as of yesterday. Now, what he can ask is that the Speaker should give direction going forward in matters such as this, whether the direction should be expressed, because it did not appear. So, he cannot insist that it should feature in the *Votes and Proceedings* of yesterday. That is my view on this matter.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, I think what the Hon Professor Nyarko is trying to draw our attention to is, within our practice, when a Question is asked and answered, it is, if the Member is not present to verbally ask the Question, then what I know and think is that because the Answer was provided on the *Order Paper*, and because it is not an Urgent Question, if he is not there to verbally ask it, it is presumed that it is—Yesterday, the Minority Chief Whip noticed that he was not in the Chamber, and somebody was given the authority to ask the Question. So, the Minority Chief Whip told me that he had given the authority to the person to ask the Question.

Mr Speaker, what I would tell Prof Nyarko is that since the Answer was provided in the *Order Paper*, and then the Speaker did not give any further directive, it means that the Question has been transmitted to the Ministry and the Ministry then responded to the Question. We would make a follow-up with the Table Office to see if they would re-table it or not.

Mr Speaker, other than that, we can make progress.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Correction of *Votes and Proceedings*. The *Votes and Proceedings* is a summary of what happened on the Floor of Parliament. So, if there was no direction on the Floor of Parliament, there is no way by which the *Votes and Proceedings* will capture a direction. The usual thing has not happened. It did not happen in the sense that normally if you are not going

to be available, you authorise another Hon Member to ask the Question on your behalf. In this case, the Question was called, no authority—the Hon Member was not there, and there was no direction. So, the *Votes and Proceedings* cannot on its own, give directions which did not happen on the Floor of Parliament. So, in correcting the *Votes and Proceedings* let us take note of what actually transpired in Parliament, and if that has not been accurately captured, then we can raise it.

Page 13—Yes, Hon Lukutor?

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor: Mr Speaker, just a minor correction in Question 503 and 504, as it is in the *Votes and Proceedings*. If we look at the name of Mr Tweneboa Kodua Fokuo, at 470, I think the correct spelling of Fokuo is there, Fokuo but at 503 and 504, it is spelled as Fokua. So, maybe the Table will want to look at the spelling.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note of the correct spelling.

Page 14—Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Chairman for the Committee on Health, Dr Mark Kurt Nawaane. Nawaane is spelt with “N and A” and, consequentially, on page 15 as well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Table Office, take consequential note.

Page 16...19—Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, briefly on page 19. Item number 2, roman numeral iii. After “Ohene”, let us delete the word there and insert “Frimpong”.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table, take note.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 10th February, 2026, as corrected, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, we have two *Official Reports*. The *Official Reports* of 3rd and 4th February, 2026. Let us first correct the *Official Report* of 3rd February, 2026.

Hon Members, it is for your correction. Any corrections? Hon Stephen Amoah, are you up to correct the *Official Report*?

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Tuesday, 3rd February, 2026]

[No correction was made to the Official Report of Wednesday, 4th February, 2026]

2:30 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I just made some observations in the Chamber. I can see that the Majority Chief Whip and many of our Colleagues are in smocks. Yesterday, the Speaker said that he does not want us to recite the

National Pledge again because what comes out of our mouths does not correspond with our actions.

Mr Speaker, a smock is a traditional wear, and if they want to wear it, they have to wear it properly. Look at how the Member of Parliament for Nalerigu-Gambaga, Hon Nurideen Mumuni, has worn it. Mr Speaker, when you wear the smock, you put on the hat. The Majority Chief Whip is not properly dressed in the smock. The Minister for Sports and Recreation is not properly dressed. So, if they want to obey the directives of the President and, for that matter, promote Ghanaian wear, they should do it properly. Even Hon Doyoe and our women are wearing their own thing. Prof Alidu is properly represented. There are meanings as to how to wear the hat. Mr Speaker, in wearing the hat, there are some directions that if you put it on and you are not careful, traditionally, you will not live to see the next day. Other directions of the hat are of a spiritual nature, and when you put it—I could see that some of them are trying to tell us that there is nobody close to them. That is the meaning of some of the hats that they wear. They should be able to copy what Hon Nurideen Mumuni is wearing.

Mr Speaker, you know your friend is the Chief of Smocks in the Northern Region. I know that the Yaa Naa installed Chief of Smocks is your friend. So, when you dress, you dress properly. But the Majority Chief Whip cannot dress like this. Look at how Hon Zuwera is dressed. My good Friend, Hon Doyoe, cannot be dressed like that. Mr Speaker, they are abusing the wearing of smocks.

They are abusing it; they are not properly dressed—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, do not forget that I am the son of Yaa Naa. On this occasion, you are completely out of order.

Majority Chief Whip, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, what exactly is the First Deputy Minority Whip saying? Is there a formula for wearing the smock? Which is common to which traditional area? The Hon Member is urging us to a certain standardised formula of wearing the smock, and I am asking if it is accustomed to any particular traditional area. In my traditional area, in Tongor-Tsanakpe in South Dayi, this is how we wear the smock. Is he saying that smocks are only accustomed to his traditional area? Is that what he is thinking? What we call a smock, *fugu*, or *batakari* is accustomed to my traditional area. This is our *batakari*, this is how we wear it. And he is seeking to urge us to his practice in Tolon.

Mr Speaker, he is completely out of order.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, he is a Voltarian. Look at how he is dressed. That Hon Member is from the Bono Region; look at how he is dressed. Hon Zuwera from that Savannah Region; look at how she is dressed. Ask the Majority Leader; if one is wearing smock, one must wear it properly. So, they should not abuse the directive of the

President, and when he wants to obey the directive of the President, he should obey it holistically. Do not obey it partially. When he wants to wear it, he should dress properly —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, I rule you out of order. The dress that you are putting on, if it pleases the person wearing it, that person can put on a hat. But that does not mean that you are putting it on without a hat means that you are improperly dressed.

Majority Chief Whip, any indication?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is so.

May I urge you that we take the item numbered 6 — Statements. Mr Speaker, my prayer is that we take the first one, and then there is one that is commemorative of today being the newly declared National Fugu Day. And so, a Statement from a Member has been recommended for admission so that it can be taken on the Floor.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, the Statements admitted are spelt out in the Order Paper. Which one do you prioritise?

Mr Dafeamekpor: The first one.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Frank Annoh- Dompreeh: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip is suggesting that we take the first Statement as advertised. We have the

second Statement that stands in the name of Dr Stephen Amoah. I suggest we take the two Statements. We take the one that stands in the name of Hon Ntoso, after which, we can proceed to take the one that stands in the name of Dr Stephen Amoah. So, two Statements should be taken for now. After which, we can decide whether to proceed to take Questions or not. For the Chief Whip to mention only one Statement is unfortunate. So, we would start with the Statement that the Majority Chief Whip mentioned, and proceed to the second Statement. We would take two Statements for now.

Mr Dafeamekpor: My prayer is that we take Statements; we would take the first one as advertised. But we have one Statement that is commemorative of today being the newly declared National Fugu Day. So, my prayer is that the second Statement will be that one. We have recommended it to you for admission. Mr Speaker, if it has not been admitted, I will yield, then we would take the first two Statements as advertised, and move to the other Businesses. That is all I am saying.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Statements are admitted for processing. Any time a Statement is admitted, the Statement will have to be processed. And the processing means that it goes through the requirements, and it is captured on the Order Paper. So, if the Statement is not on the Order Paper, probably the Statement has not been processed.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, in this House, we often agree to disagree. I do not have a problem if we have to take the Statement on the commemoration of the National Fugu Day. But let us take the first two Statements, which are advertised, after which we can take the commemorative Statement. That would be fine.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So clearly, we are taking three Statements for now, including the one that is not processed but admitted. Very well. We have the first Statement which stands in the name of Hon Helen Adjoa Ntoso, Member of Parliament for Krachi West.

2:40 p. m.

STATEMENTS

Volta Lake Boat Disaster

Ms Helen Adjoa Ntoso (NDC — Krachi West): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to make this important Statement on a heartbreaking incident that occurred in my Constituency. This happened last year, but my Statement has now been admitted.

Mr Speaker, a tragic accident occurred on 11th October, 2025, on the Volta Lake at Okumah, an island community in the Krachi West Constituency, which claimed the lives of 16 individuals, including 11 children.

Mr Speaker, the boat which was carrying over 20 passengers travelling from Okumah to Debume to attend the

funeral of a beloved one regrettably capsised. Preliminary reports suggest that overloading and poor safety measures may have contributed to this devastating tragedy. This heartbreaking event has left families and the entire community in deep mourning. Our hearts and prayers go out to the bereaved families and all those affected by this irreparable loss. The sole survivors of this tragic incident are a young lady and her baby; in a family of nine, she lost both her parents and all her siblings.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Maritime Authority has since launched an investigation into the incident, while the Government has given some support to the affected families, including the payment of funeral expenses. The Vice President, Her Excellency Prof Naana Jane Opoku-Agyemang, has also visited the community to express her condolences and also donated life jackets and other relief items to the victims' families and survivors. The Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Engineers and Planners, a Ghanaian businessman and philanthropist, Mr Ibrahim Mahama, in a prompt response, donated 200 life jackets when the incident occurred. My gratitude goes to them, not forgetting the Oti Regional Minister, the Director General of the National Disaster Management Organisation (NADMO), the Minister for Transport, staff of the Ghana Maritime Authority and all the security agencies for their prompt response.

Mr Speaker, this painful tragedy serves as yet another reminder of the urgent need to enforce strict safety

standards on our waterways. We must ensure that boats are not overloaded, that operators are properly trained and licensed, and that every passenger wears a life jacket before boarding.

In this regard, Mr Speaker, I wish to once again make a passionate appeal to the Government, corporate organisations, benevolent individuals, and non-governmental organisations (NGOs) to come to the aid of the people of Krachi West by donating more life jackets to our island communities and other settlements along the riverbanks, whose only means of transportation is by water. The supply we currently have is woefully inadequate. Many of my constituents rely on the Volta Lake for daily transportation, trade and access to education and healthcare facilities. Equipping them with proper safety gear will go a long way in saving lives.

Furthermore, Mr Speaker, I urge all community members, boat operators and all users of water transport, to strictly adhere to safety protocols when travelling on our water bodies. No life should be lost again because of non-compliance with basic safety rules. Together we can build a culture of safety and responsibility on our waterways.

May the souls of the departed rest peacefully in the Lord, and may their families find comfort and strength during this difficult time.

I thank you once again, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity you have given me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Member.

The Statement has been made; it is now time for comments. Leadership, having regard to the number of the Statements that we have, how many contributors do we take?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we propose that we do one apiece, then one each from Leadership, making two from each Side per Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: That is fine with us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Matthew Nyindam, you have the floor.

Mr Matthew Nyimdam (NPP — Kpandai): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by my Aunty. My sympathies to the family that lost lives on the Volta Lake.

Mr Speaker, I know Statements are not supposed to generate debate, and I hope my contribution towards this Statement does not generate a debate. I want to start by saying that the Ministry of Transport and the Volta Lake Authority pay little attention to people who travel by lake. If you take the stretch Krachi to Kajeji, Makango to Yeji, from Lonto to Yeji, Dambai, all along Kitare stretch, the main means transport of the people who live along these areas is by boat. But unfortunately, these people travel without any protection and sometimes they stay on the lake for

almost three hours. Some of the boats are such that they can carry about 50 to 100 people. There is no regulation. The authorities see them and are unconcerned, but when disasters like this come up, we would be here to make Statements and complain. The authorities will go and donate one or two things and that ends the story. The following day, the same thing happens.

So, I want to urge the Ministry of Transport and the Volta Lake Authority that they should take more interest because the attention that we give to these commuters is very poor. It is so poor that if we as a nation do not put in measures to support these individuals, because it is privately owned, Government does not have any direct intervention when it comes to the use of the Volta Lake, apart from the pontoons that run from one end to the other. When it comes to the boats, they are privately owned. And because they are privately owned, Government does not give much attention to these areas.

The maker of the Statement just spoke about the life jackets. Mr Speaker, most of the people who use the lake do not put on their life jackets. Some do not even have it at all. So, I want to urge that in as much as we want to contribute and sympathise with families who lost their dear ones to this accident, I will pray that when this Statement ends, let us get the Ministry of Transport to come and tell this House how best they can support these private boat owners to give life jackets for free, and then get some control and do monitoring. You do not just give the jackets and that is it. You

give the jackets and put in measures to make sure that those people who board these pontoons or boats make use of them. If we all put in some of these measures, I am very positive-minded that we will save lives, instead of coming to the Floor to contribute and mourn people who lost their lives.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

2:50 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I will proceed to give the floor to—Hon Doyoe, are you on your feet?

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. *[Laughter]*

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are not Hon Doyoe; nevertheless, you have the floor.

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by my senior Colleague, the Hon Member for Krachi West.

Mr Speaker, those of us who have our constituencies bordering the Volta Lake wake up every morning and pray we do not get a phone call from the constituency announcing a boat cracking, a boat drowning, or a capsizing, because it has become the bane of our people. When this particular

crash happened, and I heard about it, the first thing I did was to call the Municipal Chief Executive of my constituency to find out whether there were any persons from my constituency on the boat. He, in turn, called his colleague in Krachi West and reassured me that we had not suffered any casualties. The reason is that I share a border with Krachi West, and some constituents from Krachi West live in my constituency, and vice versa. When these things happen, it is not only about the people of Krachi West. It is about all of us; any of our relatives, our friends, or our associates could have been on that boat that day. So, it brings home the need for us to do something about this situation that keeps recurring.

Mr Speaker, not too long ago, we received a Statement from Hon Bede Ziedeng. The same thing had happened in his constituency. I think we need to look holistically at how we can address this situation. I think the Ghana Maritime Authority should begin to look at deploying safety boats so they are on hand immediately when a disaster strikes to assist victims. We can travel the whole stretch of the Volta Lake from Dambai to Kijewu and not see one single form of assistance for the users of the Lake. At the end of the day, it is the only mode of travel for these communities. They carry their goods; they carry their children. In some of the lakeside communities that do not have schools, they ferry their children on boats to the next community with a school. Some of the communities do not have clinics. When a woman is in labour, she has to be ferried across the lake to the nearest community with a clinic.

So, there is a whole developmental gap around this area of the Volta Lake. I think that it is about time that all of us make concerted efforts to look at how to bring relief to our people. It should not be the case that when our people get on the boat to cross to the next community, we are apprehensive. We should be able to relax knowing they are safe, will get to their destination, and will come home.

And that brings to mind, Mr Speaker, the quality of the boats on the lake. Because they are privately owned, as my Colleague said, no one pays attention. We, your Members of Parliament (MPs), sit in the boats on the lake when we go campaigning or visiting our constituents. And we will find a child with a bucket and a cup scooping water because there is leakage and water is getting into the boat. So if anyone loses attention and water collects in the boat, it sinks. We need to begin to look at the quality of boats on the river. We need to look at a licensing regime that will have a full protocol of assessments that boat owners must provide and physical inspections undertaken before they are licenced to operate on these lakes.

Mr Speaker, I want to add my voice to the Hon Member for Krachi West to thank all the people who came to her aid and the aid of the victims. Because invariably, when these things happen, it ends at the doorstep of the MP. The MP must bear the medical costs, burial costs, and the cost of evacuating the bodies. And so, once we get people to support us, we want to show appreciation and pray that they will keep giving so we can help our people along the lakes. The people

who live along the Volta Lake are Ghanaians—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, let us observe Order 93(5). The comment must not exceed five minutes.

Ms Ibrahimah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

The Government needs to pay attention to them and find a way to mainstream them into this country's development agenda. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, let me show solidarity with our Colleague for the Statement made. I am reliably informed that the incident occurred some three months ago. But it is still important to show solidarity and share in the pain of the victims of the constituency. I identify with Many of the regrets and views expressed by Members, except to add that, for instance, the White Volta, the Black Volta, and the Volta Lake serve as a very important means of transport. Elsewhere in many parts of the world, such means of transport have been developed and serve as reliable means of transport. But in our parts of the world, we often take things for granted. The Ministry of Transport, for instance, comes in the wake. It is regrettable that most of the facilities on these water bodies do not have life jackets. They are basic facilities that should be found in these facilities.

So it is not a matter we have to belabour. We should be revolving around the reasons life jackets and such safety measures cannot be upheld because no one can ever justify why these safety measures are not upheld on these transport facilities. And we keep losing lives every now and then. So I think the duty bearers would have to respond to this matter and track it down once and for all. Accidents that occur as a result of compromised safety measures are things that we cannot tolerate and eventually lead to loss of life and loss of property. I think it is high time we drew the line and drew the curtains on these concerns. So it is important, and our hearts go out to the Hon Member.

We cannot inflict pain on our people and we come to show regret and call for paltry sums of money or support for affected victims, even though these accidents could have been avoided.

3:00 p.m.

So, Mr Speaker, not to belabour the point, we must call on all the duty bearers, particularly the Ministry of Transport and all the parastatal bodies who are involved, to let it be a thing of the past, and for us to bring finality to this needless and unavoidable accident that occurs on our water bodies.

The last time I recall, Hon Bede Ziedeng had a cause to present a Statement in this House, and it was on the White Volta, and many lives were lost.

So, Hon Ntoso, our hearts go out to you, but we should use it as a springboard to inflict on other

occurrences on the White Volta, the Black Volta and the other water bodies we have in our country, where these accidents are occurring every now and then, and to deal with them once and for all.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minority Chief Whip.

Yes, Hon Minister for Sports and Recreation, Hon Kofi Adams?

Minister for Sports and Recreation (Mr Kofi Iddie Adams): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a few comments on the Statement made by our Colleague, the Member of Parliament for Krachi West, on this disaster that happened last year.

Mr Speaker, like other Members have indicated, this is not the first time we are experiencing such an occurrence. It happens, we come, we make Statements and after that it ends there. What is clearly necessary is the need to formalise the water transport system in this country. As some Members have indicated, the water transport system is supposed to be the safest and most reliable in many countries. Unfortunately, in Ghana, it is not the case. It is either we have failed to remove the stumps that need to be removed so that the path can be safe for them, or the boats that they use are so outmoded and are not water worthy.

Mr Speaker, in the same way that we take our vehicles to the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority (DVLA) examination points, for these vehicles to be examined for renewal of licences and road worthiness, same must apply to the boats so that there is a system to check whether these boats that are used to carry persons from one point to the other are truly water worthy, just as we do for vehicles.

Mr Speaker, in most cases, enforcement is also key, but do we have enforcement systems at the riverbanks where they start from? Sometimes, no. If we have MTTD officers on our roads that deal with road transport, should it not be the case that we have something on the water transport system that will be checking this, and possibly even have water patrol units' communication? In aviation, there is always a tracking of every flight that moves from one airport to another. What happens to the boats when they are on the water bodies? Who checks where they are moving to? Who gives them the weather readings to know that this is the weather situation on the lake they are going to be moving on?

So, it is important we formalise the system, but I am happy that the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways and the Government have commenced serious steps to build bridges over three critical water bodies, namely, the Oti Bridge, Volivo and Adawso-Ekye Amanfrom. That is a great step, and I believe we should extend some of these services to our normal water transport system.

We truly empathise with the families that have lost their loved ones and the two surviving ones. These are times when you ask yourself whether it was good to be alive or you should have joined your family because to lose nine family members; sometimes you ask yourself, if you should live or you should just join them. I know what they will be going through. It may not be enough just to give them some goods and services. We must extend clinical psychological help to them, because they will be going through a lot of trauma.

But Mr Speaker, the most important thing is to also make sure that we enforce rules. Some people will refuse to wear life jackets. They will either claim that it is dirty or that it has been worn by somebody else, so they do not want to wear it. For any person boarding a boat, whether they know how to swim or not, there is a need to insist that they wear a life jacket. So, it is not enough to mobilise more life jackets, but we must make sure that they wear them because it protects their lives.

Mr Speaker, once again, we need to formalise our water transport system. It will even take off the pressure on our roads, and for communities that do not have such roads to use, and use the water transport system, this is the only way we can save them.

Mr Speaker, I do not pray for any Member to come and make a Statement yet again about such losses. We want to formalise the system. We want to make sure we insist and that people will do

what we expect them to do when we donate some of these life jackets to them.

I wish to thank all donors, especially the Vice President, who made time to attend to them when the disaster occurred.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, that brings us to the end of the Statement ably made by Hon Helen Adjoa Ntoso. Before we proceed to the second Statement for the day, permit me to acknowledge the presence of our dear students visiting us in Parliament.

We have students from Wemase D/A Junior High School, led by Richard Adade-Boateng, the head teacher. They are from Akrofuom, and are numbered 85.

[Students of Wamase D/A Junior High School were acknowledged]

We also have students from Ningo Senior High Technical School, led by Mr James Watemberg, the Assistant Head of Department. They are from Ningo-Prampram and are numbered 75.

[Students of Ningo Senior High Technical School were acknowledged]

We also have students from Abepotia Presby, led by Ms Rebecca Naa Merley Larbi, the Project Director. They are from Kwahu South and are numbered 80.

[Students of Abepotia Presby were acknowledged]

Finally, we have students from Abor Senior High School, led by Rev Dr Seth Agbeyume, the headmaster. They are from the Keta Constituency and are numbered 90.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am a proud old student of Abor Secondary School.

Hon Members, I was a senior prefect in the 1992/93 academic year. Yes, the old system and Hon Members, I can proudly say that I am the first student to become a lawyer. I am also the first student to become a Member of Parliament. *[Hear! Hear!]*

So, I use the opportunity to welcome all our students to Parliament. I urge you to have a very fruitful visit to the Parliament of the Republic of Ghana.

[Students of Abor Senior High School were acknowledged]

3:10 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have a second Statement standing in the name of Dr Stephen Amoah, Member for Parliament for Nhyiaeso who will be making a Statement on entrepreneurship as part of Ghana's basic and Senior High School academic curriculum. Hon Stephen Amoah, you have the floor.

Making Entrepreneurship Part of Ghana's Basic and SHS Academic Curricula

Dr Stephen Amoah (NPP — Nhyiaeso): Mr Speaker, it is a pleasure to have this opportunity to present a

Statement on another critical national issue, which is the impact of entrepreneurship on the global economy, and a need to consider that as a course in both Ghana's junior high school and senior high school academic curricula.

Mr Speaker, entrepreneurship is the ability to set up a new business venture and develop one's own business with the intention of making profit instead of rely on ones already created by another individual or corporate body. Mr Speaker, there are a number of compelling reasons for the above proposition to be accorded the needed national and Executive attention. Entrepreneurship has played a remarkable role and indeed become an integral part of the global economy. It has impacted the economy by creating jobs, stimulating economic stability, and reducing poverty in the world.

The job market in Ghana, Mr Speaker, is congested, leaving most of the youth in an undesirable employment space. The unemployment rate in Ghana has tremendously contributed to most of the antisocial behaviours in Ghana, including insecurity, robbery, drug abuse, teenage pregnancy, and sexually transmitted diseases. Mr Speaker, the Institute of Statistical, Social, and Economic Research' (ISSER) data indicate that only about 10 per cent of Ghanaian graduates secure employment within a year of graduation. Besides, the Statistical Service indicates that graduate job-hunting duration is about five years. What it means is that it takes about five years for them to even get regular jobs. In Ghana, according to the Ghana Education Sector Report, about 109,874

graduates from the university education system annually. What it means is that only about 10,000 of this number get employed annually, leaving about an estimated figure of 100,000 unemployed graduates.

Mr Speaker, the way to go all over the world is entrepreneurship as the private sector is the engine of global socioeconomic growth. It was entrepreneurs who replaced home kerosene lamps with brighter and cleaner-burning gas in the middle to late 1800s. Those ones also were displaced by a better electric light system and later came fluorescent lighting. Entrepreneurs invent a lot of new technologies, computers, the World Wide Web, the spreadsheet, and the new improved drug technologies.

Mr Speaker, entrepreneurship is the key to dealing comprehensively with the graduate unemployment in Ghana. A lot of our talents, out of frustration, engage in a lot of illicit socioeconomic ventures and even leave the shores of Ghana in search of greener pastures. These factors have affected Ghana's skill labour and are highly dysfunctional to the performance of our Republic. The unemployment situation has a degree of integration when it comes to insecurity and an unstable economy.

A developing economy such as Ghana, which has been endowed with a wide range of commercially viable raw materials and natural resources offer an entrepreneurial opportunity for job creation. There are, however, many setbacks to our quest to create a

sustainable entrepreneurial ecosystem in Ghana as a substitution or supplement policy. We have a very weak entrepreneurial ecosystem as a country. The interactions among the relevant stakeholders in the entrepreneurial ecosystem lack not only the requisite structural and functional capacity, but also the effectiveness to augment the employment capacity of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, there are a number of proposed solutions, including redefining our corporate focus as a country, governments be intentional about entrepreneurship in its major policy decisions, and realigning and harmonising the key stakeholders in the ecosystem. Apart from creating jobs, boosting Ghana's economy, and diminishing Government's burden, entrepreneurship, if well integrated, will go a long way to answer most of our economic questions as a sovereignty. Additionally, it will play an illustrative role in Ghana's import-driven agenda and realisation.

The most needed solution emphasised in this Statement is the advocacy for the inclusion of "Entrepreneurship" as a course in the junior high school academic curriculum and as elective in the senior high school academic curriculum.

Mr Speaker, permit me to repeat this extract, just because it forms the integral part of my Statement. The most needed solution emphasised in this Statement is the advocacy for the inclusion of "Entrepreneurship" as a core course in the junior high school academic

curriculum and as elective course in the senior high school academic curriculum.

I am accordingly proposing that the relevant stakeholder bodies, particularly the Ministry of Education, take the needed steps to expedite action on the inclusion of entrepreneurship in our JHS and SHS academic curriculum. This will increase the entrepreneurship appetite of our youth to start and develop their own businesses. Mr Speaker, I thank you for honouring me with this great opportunity. Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Statement ably made. It is now for Hon Members to contribute. Subject to the same agreement, we will take one each and Leadership. I will yield the floor to Hon Peter Nortsu-Kotoe.

Mr Peter Nortsu-Kotoe (NDC — Akatsi North): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by Dr Stephen Amoah, Member of Parliament for the Nhyiaeso Constituency. It is true that unemployment in Ghana is a challenge; a challenge that has to be addressed by everybody. It is also true that it is important that we make our learners develop skills that will help them in the future, rather than always depending on Government for employment.

3:20 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as you said, entrepreneurship is the ability to set up a new business venture and develop one's own business. But where I have a small

challenge is the introduction of entrepreneurship at the basic education level. Already, we have so many subjects studied at the basic education level, which for some of us is even too much. What is important at the basic level is foundational learning. How do we make sure that the learner at the basic level is able to do very well, especially in reading and writing? When we go to a number of public basic schools now, the ability to read fluently is not there and to even write is a challenge, which I know the Ministry of Education is seriously addressing.

So, for basic schools, we need to allow them to make sure that they lay the foundation for education of our children. Let us give them that foundational learning so that they can read and write and understand why they are in school.

A few years ago, we had the education reform programme where technical and vocational studies or education was introduced into our basic education system. That was when we introduced the junior high school programme. Tools were supplied to our schools so that students could learn some skills at the basic level. Unfortunately, that was not followed to the letter. So, what has happened is that we cannot even find those tools that were supplied to all the junior high schools in those days, and the programme did not go further. It was then that even some learned how to handle basic carpentry tools. If we had continued with that, I am sure that it would have impacted them very much, because some learners at that time could even make chairs and tables

in the basic school. But unfortunately, that programme was not followed vigorously.

Mr Speaker, if we go to our senior high schools, many of them offer business subjects. To make it a complete core subject is where I have my problem. We can incorporate it into social studies. Because if we go to the senior high schools, so many subjects are being studied there; three or four core subjects then three or four elective subjects. So, if we burden them with so many subjects — now that their performances are giving us a headache, we need to look at it critically. This is so that in reviewing the curriculum as we are doing now, this can be incorporated in Social Studies as a core subject, so that the students can be taught entrepreneurship.

Also, when we get to the tertiary level, we realise that a number of graduates that are being produced these days are not given any skills which they can develop. So, it is important that we also draw the attention of the university authorities that they should not only produce graduates who are not self-employable. Because once they leave the universities, they expect government to employ them, and that is creating a problem for the nation. So, it is important that the universities, especially the technical universities, produce graduates who can be entrepreneurs in the future.

With Government projects that are in the pipeline or being rolled out, it is important that the universities and technical institutes also take advantage of this and make sure that they develop skills in Ghanaian learners, so that they

can be their own employers. Mr Speaker, on that note, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Dr Mohammed Amin Adam (NPP — Karaga): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I would like to, first of all, commend Hon Stephen Amoah, my former Deputy Minister, for this Statement. The issue of entrepreneurship is critical for the growth of our economy and for the overall development of our country.

Entrepreneurship drives economies, and Ghana's economy is no exception. Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) are critical because they contribute about 70 per cent to the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) of our country. Ninety-two per cent of all businesses registered in Ghana are SMEs. As far as job creation is concerned, they also contribute about 80 per cent of jobs in the country.

Now, the SMEs cannot succeed if they do not have the entrepreneurial spirit as well as the skills required to innovate and to provide leadership to the small businesses. This is why the Statement is so important; trying to address this gap of lack of entrepreneurial skills at the basic level of our education. It is important because when we start giving the young ones the skills, the entrepreneurial spirit and endowment, they can grow to become successful entrepreneurs in the country. So, I support this Statement because I think that starting the solution at the basic level is so critical.

Mr Speaker, apart from this, I also think that we must begin to address this

issue also among the existing SMEs, as most of the SMEs are not successful because they do not have those skills and training. Apart from capital constraints, the other key constraint is the entrepreneurial skills. So apart from the basic schools, existing SMEs also need that support. So, I recommend that we set up SME clinics across the country in communities, districts and regions, so that SMEs can walk into these clinics to get entrepreneurial skills, training and guidance on where they can get capital and how they can transform their businesses. This is so that they can become successful to continue to create jobs for our country and to continue to contribute to the GDP of our country.

Mr Speaker, this Statement really needs to be looked at seriously. The last time we passed the 24-Hour Economy Authority Bill, 2025, I wanted to see emphasis on providing entrepreneurial skills to SMEs. I hope that the Authority, once established, will give attention to the issue of providing entrepreneurial training and skills to SMEs who are the bedrock of our economy. This would enable them to double their profits, expand their businesses, and create jobs for the youth in particular. Graduates, especially those that are coming out of our universities and our technical schools need that opportunity to be absorbed, to apply the training and technical skills they have acquired in schools. But if we do not have that opportunity or platform, we will continue to read petitions by unemployed graduates associations in our country, which really does not augur well for us.

We all agree that unemployment is a security threat and all efforts must be made to address the issue of unemployment. But more so, when individuals are supported to set up their own businesses, to realise the entrepreneurial ingenuity of these young ones, it will go a long way to complement what Government is doing and thereby help us address the security threat which unemployment is posing to our country. I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much, Hon Member. Let us take one from each Side and then Leadership. The Statement emanated from the Minority Side, so there was one on the Majority Side and one on the Minority Side. So now, Minority Leadership.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: So, Mr Speaker, we are ceding to Hon Samuel Awuku.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Samuel Awuku, you have the floor.

3:30 p.m.

Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Thank you Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I rise to add my voice to the maker of the Statement and the very proposal that he has put forward.

Mr Speaker, we are seeking to solve a problem which is youth unemployment. On the African continent today, the

biggest problem we are facing is unemployment. Whereas the government sector is choked, I believe that the most viable place to look at is the private sector.

The private sector cannot also function when the entrepreneurial aspect is not there. I believe that inculcating in our kids and young learners right from the basic education level through the senior high school with a core in entrepreneurship and an elective in entrepreneurship will help develop their minds and tune them towards the problem that we seek to solve.

Mr Speaker, even the maker of the Statement was charitable with some of the figures. For instance, if we are talking about almost 110,000 young people graduating from university education system and 10,000 of them get to secure jobs annually; we have not even added that of the polytechnics and the other tertiary institutions. This means we are talking about close to 150,000 young people a year, passing out of our tertiary system and looking out for jobs. The public sector cannot absorb these huge numbers that we are talking about.

Again, in moving beyond even what the maker of the Statement did put across, it is a very serious matter even within the government sector when it comes to entrepreneurship. We can have somebody applying for some support, for example, at the Youth Employment Agency (YEA). This person secures that support in the area of entrepreneurship, moves to the National Entrepreneurship and Innovation Programme (NEIP),

secures another funding or support in the area of entrepreneurship. Because of the lack of checks and balances, we can have the same person or entity moving towards Government.

Before we realise, one individual might even secure three different avenues or opportunities and there is nobody even tracking it. I strongly believe that one, starting from the base of inculcating in our young learners that mindset—because business starts from conception. Once they have the mindset, how to develop it becomes the next step to take. I believe that at the basic level, we can begin to fine-tune some of these ideas and by the time that they get to the senior high school, they become much more interested in the entrepreneurship sector.

Mr Speaker, the way we even teach some of our courses in our schools is a major impediment in young people even loving these courses. Very few Ghanaians get to love French at the basic level. This is because of even how it is taught and the mode of instructions that it comes through.

Another one is that of Mathematics. So, if one is going to even treat entrepreneurship in our local parlance as *ɔkɔtɔn adeɛ* then the people will not even love it. They will not even participate fully in it. But when we make it a policy, where we are building future captains of industry and employers right from the younger generation, I believe that it will set the tone for us to considerably reduce the issue of unemployment.

So, I am fortified in my belief that starting from the basic level and fine-tuning the minds of these young learners, taking them through the mile, through the senior high school, by the time they get to the universities and the tertiary level, it would be us building right from the beginning the future Bill Gates, Elon Musk, and the big boys in the business world.

On this note, I support wholeheartedly the Statement put forward by the maker of the Statement. Let me also commend the maker of the Statement who is one of the topmost economists and financial people that we have in our country. *[Laughter]*

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Yes, Hon Majority Leader—Order! Order!

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, I think we need to commend the maker of the Statement for bringing up an important matter like this for us as legislators to ruminate over and more importantly, proffer some solutions. I do agree that entrepreneurship is a problem. Entrepreneurial skills is a problem. But I think that there is something more fundamental than just entrepreneurial skills.

Indeed, many of our people are entrepreneurial in their orientation. They do work hard to try and build businesses.

The troubles that our market women go through, travelling across the country to save and buy off commodities from our farmers, the challenges they have hauling their commodities to the market centres and how to preserve the commodities and all that, demonstrate resilience in terms of the entrepreneurial spirit of our people.

So, I do not entirely agree that the problem of our people is entrepreneurship. There are young graduates of universities who have made efforts to set up businesses. But the problem is that, there are fundamental bottlenecks that we at policy level and in legislating must deal with. I have said this time and time again. How will our Small and Medium-sized Enterprises (SMEs) survive when we have opened our borders, so that SMEs from Asia and some other parts of the world to produce at cheaper cost and come and compete with them? It is not possible.

If our SME entrepreneurs have to pay the amount that they pay for energy, how are they going to compete? If they are going to pay the interest rates that they used to pay for loans, how are they going to compete? If they are going to use the inadequate transport infrastructure that we have, how are they going to thrive?

So yes, entrepreneurship is a problem, but there are things more fundamental that we as a people must be addressing. I had a conversation with a steel manufacturer yesterday. He has increased the capacity of his steel manufacturing plant, yet we allow other people to import steel as well. Now, his

capacity is underutilised, working at less than 30 per cent, and there is unemployment.

It means that if we got him working at 90 per cent, the extra 70 per cent will also require additional hands and all these young people who are graduating from universities will be able to also get employment.

As policy makers, let us begin to demand what we have always advocated, but perhaps have not put in place concrete steps to achieve them, which is that we must ensure the utilisation of locally made goods. Local content must not just be a rhetoric, but that it must be a policy and practical imperative. If we have steel manufacturers in Ghana, no government contract should be executed using imported steel.

No development finance projects should be implemented using imported steel. Same should apply to all the other commodities. If we did that and we implemented those policies, the medium, the small enterprises will at least be guaranteed a market.

3:40 p.m.

Enterprises will at least be guaranteed a market. Once they have access to the market, they are guaranteed income and then they can expand. Then we can see their entrepreneurial skills actually bearing fruits. It is not that they lack them. It is just that no matter how hard they try, the obstacles are enormous and few people are able to break through and that is why we see everybody

pandering to government, looking for government contracts. All those who say they are really businessmen, when we go into what they do, everybody is struggling to get some form of government contract or the other. This is because we have not created the best environment for the private sector. So, I commend the maker of the statement. Yes, there is a need for us to cultivate entrepreneurs—The curriculum, starting from senior high school to tertiary education must be oriented towards generating a generation that is entrepreneurial in their skills and orientation. But that also speaks to the manner in which education is delivered.

Mr Speaker, education is not delivered in the entrepreneurial sector. You go to some jurisdictions like Austria. In Austria, education takes place in the enterprise. The enterprises are actually the schools and government is simply a regulator of the entrepreneurs and how they train the next generation of entrepreneurs, engineers, scientists *et cetera*. So even when there is a serious global unemployment crisis, when we go to a place like Austria, they do not have a problem with unemployment because almost everybody has some skills, can work and they use their skills to make their money. The system pays according to their entrepreneurial skills and engineering skills. When we go to a hotel in Austria, the best paid is not the manager. The best paid is the chef because it is because of his food that people come to that hotel. So, he gets more paid than the manager of the hotel. He gets paid better than the accountant of the hotel. This is because the real driver

of the customers is the person who is delivering on what they actually want. So here, we find that people who wear suit and tie and sit in offices, tend to be the most well-paid and so everybody wants to wear a suit. Everybody wants to wear a tie. Even on days when we all have to wear smocks; they will wear suits and ties and come and sit in the Chamber and then they deliver big speeches about entrepreneurship.

Mr Speaker, the smock makers and tailors—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, are you aware I am wearing a coat and tie? [*Laughter*]

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am not talking about Speakers. Speakers are not involved. According to the best tradition of Parliamentary practice, Speakers are actually supposed to dress this way.

Mr Speaker, I commend the maker of the Statement. I think that we should take this discussion seriously and let us begin as a House, beyond these Statements, to think practically, conduct hearings, invite all the stakeholders, and then come out with comprehensive proposals for policymakers regarding exactly what needs to be done to build entrepreneurial skills.

Mr Speaker, on that note, I thank the maker of the Statement for such a brilliant Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, indulge me before we move to the third Statement. This is an oversight.

I have in the House Mr Raphael Edem Yawlui, who is the president of the Old Students Association of Abor Secondary School. We also have Agbotadua Emmanuel Adonu. He is an all-year batch representative.

[Representatives of Old Students Association of Abor Secondary School were acknowledged].

Hon Members, I am to announce to you that the school marks its 60th anniversary on Saturday, 21st February, 2026 at Abor Senior High School premises, and you are all invited. No, here we do not clap, we say. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Yes, we have the third Statement by agreement standing in the name of Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe. Is that not it? Yes, please speak into the microphone.

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Mr Speaker, I made my Statement yesterday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, who is the Statement standing in the name of?

Ms Cudjoe: Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah, you have the floor.

Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I cannot find such Statement advertised under Statements in the *Order Paper*.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I guess you came in late. Initially, when we were agreeing on the number of Statements to be taken, the Minority Whip agreed with the Majority Whip that it could be taken as the third Statement. That is why—

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, what is the Statement about?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: She will read it and you will know what the Statement is about.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, with respect, we do not have copies of the Statement. The Statement is not on our console like other constituencies. Nobody knows anything about it so if we can get copies of the Statement whilst she makes the Statement. No, if she is going to make a Statement on *fugu*, she is not even properly dressed in the *fugu*. Yes, look at how she is dressed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, Majority Leader, in the circumstances, what do we do?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, sufficient copies have been distributed to Hon Members. Mr Speaker, sufficient within the standard protocols that will take two Hon Members who would comment on each Side and they have sufficient copies.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please do not change the rule. We agreed on an Hon Member each plus Leadership.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, yes, I agree with you. So sufficient copies have been distributed. I believe that we should be able to take the Statement.

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, respectfully, I do not know if you have sighted the said Statement and have admitted same.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please, speak for yourself. Do not speak for me.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are supposed to be guided by you. If you have sighted and have admitted same.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, let me provide a guidance. My guidance is that once the Whips agree that this will be the third Statement, I am giving the opportunity to the Hon Member to read the third Statement.

Hon Member, you have the floor. Are you ready to read the Statement or not?

Statement on Fugu and the Ghanaian Heritage

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu-Ketan): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this brief Statement on the distinguished *fugu* and its Ghanaian heritage. The iconic Ghanaian smock, locally known as *fugu* or *batakari* in my local language, traces its origin to the Northern and

Savannah regions of Ghana, to the ancient Dagomba, Mamprusi and Gonja kingdoms emerging around the 15th century.

Mr Speaker, traditionally woven from strips of cotton grown in the savannah soils of Tamale, Yendi, Salaga and neighbouring towns, the creation of *fugu* was generally influenced by the Northern Region's climate and the availability of locally produced cotton. This attire evolved from simple tunics worn by warriors and farmers to royalty and chiefs.

Mr Speaker, although deeply rooted in northern culture and embodies ethnic identity, *fugu* has over the years won the heart of the entire nation. Its tightly woven nature, interlocking motifs and signature patterns symbolises strength, authority, culture, pride and unity. It is worn in colourful displays during festivals, weddings, funerals and official gatherings.

Mr Speaker, the importance of *fugu*, especially to northern Ghana, is vital and multifaceted. Economically, it sustains thousands of weavers and traders due to its high patronage to the Northern Region and exports to the diaspora.

3:50 p.m.

This single commodity fuels large markets as well as many cultural centres, tourist sites, and the like across the country. Mr Speaker, socially, it marks status. A chief's *fugu*, heavy with silver amulets, talismans and rich design, commands respect. Like we all are

adorned in it today, it signifies its unifying capabilities. We have seen our first President of the land and the five making up the Big Six declare our independence in beautifully hand-woven smocks. As we have seen other past presidents and great leaders, regardless of tribe or political affiliation, display the beautiful attire on many occasions.

Mr Speaker, in recent times, our President, His Excellency John Dramani Mahama, has always re-echoed and educated the world on Ghana's rich culture, as he represented us on his recent trip to Zambia in a beautiful piece. Mr Speaker, today, amid urbanisation, *fugu* adapts and fits all persons and events. Fashion designers blend it with other fabrics to create a customised version. Yet, it remains a pillar not only of northern but also of Ghanaian identity. Weaving past cultural differences and ethnic resilience into national visibility, harmony, and international recognition.

Lastly, Mr Speaker, I am very glad that the Government has declared Wednesdays, a National *Fugu* Day, encouraging all Ghanaians and friends of the motherland to dedicate every Wednesday to wearing *fugu* in its various forms and designs, further promoting this outstanding traditional outfit on the world stage.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this Statement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the floor is now open. Now, I give the floor to Hon Isaac Adongo.

Mr Isaac Adongo (NDC — Bolgatanga Central): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I rise to commend the maker of this important Statement. The *fugu* or *batakari* or smock, as we have come to know, has been an age-long clothing that we use, and you can see right from the days of independence that the smock was part of our culture, even when we gained independence. In recent years, successive governments have taken turns, particularly our presidency, to outdoor the cloth called the smock. However, it appears that the effort they made to promote the smock did not gain prominence until recently, when His Excellency visited our neighbours in Zambia to foster the closer relationship that we have had with our brothers in Zambia.

Incidentally, we all know that culturally, our dressing differs from one country to another, and no particular dress is superior to the other, except that the people who wear them appreciate them the way they dress in them. So, it was not a surprise that our colleagues took exception and began to tease our President and refer to our revered clothes in very funny terms. In fact, they referred to it as a "blouse". But we can forgive them because they did not know the significance of that. As His Excellency, the President, indicated that he had worn this elegant dress in most of his engagements with the United Nations (UN) and even at the biggest world stage, the smock was featured.

Unfortunately, it was surprising to him that the people of Zambia had not noticed that he had that proverbial liking for dressing in this attire. But then our neighbour, the President of Zambia, in an attempt to atone for the misunderstanding of his people, indicated that he was on a mission to order several smocks for the people of Zambia. That gesture was a very interesting one for him to calm the social media banter that ensued.

Mr Speaker, I see the declaration by His Excellency to refer us back to wear this cloth on Wednesdays as a means to energise the industry and provide livelihood support to the people who deal in this clothing. What is important for us is that as a Government, we need to provide concrete support to the weavers and those who sew this clothing so that they can meet the emerging huge demand that we expect for the smock in our country.

So, ladies and gentlemen, I want to encourage my Colleagues, particularly for those of us from communities where this clothing is woven, to provide the support that they need so that they can meet the market demand, earn some income, and boost the local economy. Mr Speaker, this is the dawn of the Ghanaian that we have always yearned for, and that in the future, on Wednesdays, I would be happy to see the Hon Speaker in the Chair in this elegant dress so that the people of Ghana will see that we are responding to the call of His Excellency. I understand that the call was made only yesterday, and some of my Colleagues were not prepared for this day. But I know from next week I will see my good

Brother, Habib, dressed in the proverbial attire that he has been used to, and Nanton Naa will be happy to see him cladded in the proverbial smock.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity, and I thank the maker of the Statement. This is the beginning of good things to come for the smock industry in Africa and in Ghana.

Mr Kwame Anyimadu-Antwi (NPP — Asante Akim Central): Thank you, Mr Speaker. As have been said by the last speaker, some of us were not aware of this information that we had declared Wednesday to be a *fugu* wearing day. Last week, I was in my normal smock, when I was about to enter the Chamber, I met some of the pressmen who said that we had declared last Friday as *fugu* Friday. I asked why, because I did not know anything. It was Friday, and normally we wear traditional wears on Fridays. Then I was informed of the misinformation that had been given by the Zambians. Some said that our President was wearing a parachute, others also said that he was wearing a *kaba*.

Mr Speaker, this is the highest form of ignorance. This is not the first time that we are wearing smocks. We have taken it to functions, and we have taken it on travels. Everywhere in Africa and the rest of the world, anybody who sees a smock admires it. Besides, those of us who wear smocks, because they are made from cotton, it does not matter whether the weather is hot or cold; we are comfortable to wear smock. It should not take us as Parliament for the

President to wear it for people to make derogatory remarks on them before we cherish our culture. Culture is defined as a way of people, including the clothes they wear and the food they eat.

Mr Speaker, I know that several Statements have been made on the *kente* cloth. I remember when our Colleague from Bonwire was here, almost every year when they were celebrating the *Kente* festival, she gave a Statement on the *kente* cloth. I, myself, am a weaver of *kente* cloth. When I was a young boy, that was how we started it. It is part of that.

4:00 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I have lost count of the number of smocks that I have both at the constituency and in Accra here. So, it is part of us and I think that we must be certain if we are taking it on Friday as a traditional wear. It would be better. So maybe Leadership should put their heads together and if we are able to start this from Parliament, I am sure that it will transcend to the rest of Ghanaians so that the rest of the world would cherish what we wear. We must cherish it ourselves.

But now I think we are confused whether we have to wear it on Wednesdays or on Fridays. As a matter of fact, when I wore it last Friday, I did not have anything in mind that I was making a conscious effort of what we have decided on. It was a normal wear that I had worn on a Friday, and I think if we are able to go by that, it will help. So, when the press asked me, one of the things that I said was that I am not

wearing it because of H. E. President Mahama, but I would not sit down for anybody to make derogatory remarks about our President, even though I have never voted for him. I would not allow anybody to make a derogatory statement about him because he had worn a smock. This is pure ignorance. It is high time we, as parliamentarians, woke up and made sure that we are proud of our culture so that the rest of Ghana, Africa and the world would appreciate it.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much, but I still emphasise, let us come together and agree on one thing.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: We do secret balloting. Why are you announcing to us who you vote for?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I said I have never voted for him. You want to hear that again?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do we need that?

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, I am saying that where I stand, I belong to the New Patriotic Party.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, but we engage in secret balloting.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: It is obvious.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You are behaving like what happened in the just ended NPP primaries where people did not vote for Dr Mahamudu Bawumia, but I guess they are pretending they have voted for Dr Mahamudu Bawumia. For

all you know, you have also voted for President Mahama, but here you are saying you have not voted for him.

Mr Anyimadu-Antwi: Mr Speaker, that was only a reported speech I made to the press. It is nothing mischievous.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Majority Side?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I want to yield to Hajia Laadi Ayamba.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hajia Laadi Ayamba?

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, and thank you, Hon Majority Chief Whip for yielding your position to me. Let me also thank Dr Ayensu-Danquah for the Statement she made.

I overheard some people say earlier that she is not from the north. No, that is a very big mistake. Mr Speaker, the *fugu*, as it is popularly called it here, is an indigenous cloth. Although it is emanating from the northern sector as most of us know, it covers a lot of traditional areas for their own cultural purposes. The *fugu* as you have seen, these two colours I am wearing are made from my Constituency, and we have different colours. I overheard the Hon First Deputy Minority Whip talk about how the cap should be worn. Mr Speaker, even colours send messages. There is a particular colour which you will not find often worn, or it is not everybody that

wears it. In my tradition, they call it *Kpang Kɔɔbug*, the feather of a guinea fowl, meaning that there is nothing that you can do to wash the colour of a guinea fowl, no matter how much it rains. Mr Speaker, the fact is that that cloth is being used by people who are “spiritually matured”, and they use it for a whole lot of *juju* or voodoo or whatever you may call it. It is a particular type of *fugu*.

Mr Speaker, we have the white, and with that we have the very bright white, and the cream white. Many a time, you see us women using the very white cloth, especially our Queen Mothers. They like to use the very white one for our cultural purposes. You may sew it as I have, and still have a cloth like what I have to drape over your shoulders, with the edges frayed and properly woven for decorative purposes. In those days, you wear just the two. One under, and then one on the chest, and the small draped over, as I have said. It is these days that we have gone into sewing like I have sewn.

Mr Speaker, the *fugu* is a cloth accepted by many tribes, many districts, many people, and it fits basically everybody. It is not for any particular tribe, and you will realise that the late President Rawlings had a *fugu* that he used to wear, and we used to say, that is how the Ewes wear theirs. So, he would wear a long sleeve shirt underneath, and wear what we would say *Kwalung* in Kusaal, which is the small one on top of it. The Dagombas especially, have them in so many decorations and shades. The Gonjas have it the same way.

If you watch the sewing, Mr Speaker, many people do not understand, and they cannot use the sewing to tell which *fugu* comes from where. The best *fugu* you can get are those that are sewn by hand. Every thread is sewn by hand. These days, people sew them with sewing machines, and it is not as nice as the one that is hand-sewn. Now, some people these days also sew it with a sewing machine, but still use the needle and thread to decorate it. I have seen so many of them, basically almost all those here have that type. But there is one person here who is wearing the proper hand-sewn one with all the decoration. Hon Maxwell Kwame Lukutor, Member for South Tongu, is wearing the locally sewn one. [*Hear! Hear!*] Hon Yusif Sulemana is also wearing one that comes from the Gonja area, and because of my knowledge about them, I am able to tell. But we will prefer, if Hon Yusif can help us make sure that it is a properly sewn one, and that is from his hometown.

Now, I am making all these statements to corroborate what Hon Stephen Amoah has said about us supporting skill-workers or entrepreneurs. Mr Speaker, the fact is that if we are able to support the woman or the girl child, right from the growing age, very early stages—Some of them are actually not in school, but they go as apprentices to learn how to weave. The only thing they need from us is funding to buy those machines they use these days, and also to buy the thread. Some of them can hire the machine, but they do not have money to buy the thread. They need a lot of support.

Our vocational schools are doing so well, but they need that support and the market for it. If we decide that we are going to wear it on a particular day, then we should also be able to ensure that we use our good offices to support our various assemblies, to at least, identify some group of persons, both men and women who are weaving, to ensure that they produce the *fugu*. Then we can carry along with the “Fugu Day”, whether it is Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, although it has no particular day on which it should be worn. That is now for us to decide and it will make us continue to communicate to the outside world that it is not a parachute, neither is it a blouse. It is quite interesting.

4:10 p.m.

So, Mr Speaker, let us continue to work hard, support our people, and portray our culture. Let me congratulate the Rt Hon Speaker on the way he dresses for the Chamber. He has refused to stick with wearing the suit and tie every day. Mr Speaker, with all respect to you, the Rt Hon Speaker wears *fugu* or an attire from the Volta Region, Ashanti Region or any part of Ghana. Everyone agrees it is beautiful and nice—[*Hear! Hear!*]—So, let us go that way, let us buy the idea and let us project our country and ourselves.

I thank Hon Ayensu-Danquah and wish us all the best as we continue.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Minority Side has not spoken.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, after the Statement was read, only Hon Anyimadu-Antwi spoke. Nobody from our Leadership spoke.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. You have the floor.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu (NPP — Tolon): Mr Speaker, thank you, and let me also commend the maker of the Statement for this important Statement.

The President's call is in the right direction. It is a rehash of what former President Kufuor did. The then Minister for Trade, through President Kufuor, also declared Friday a day to wear *fugu* as a form of identity.

Mr Speaker, *fugu* as an African wear, originates in the Northern Region as a traditional wear. It symbolises authority, respect, and cultural identity. We must know that there are ways and forms in which this *fugu* is worn, and we must be able to identify ourselves with it. For instance, the Member of Parliament for Pusiga, Hon Ayamba, has shown the proper way for women to wear the *fugu*. It is worn as she is dressed, with the *kaba* and slit, a headscarf, and a shoulder scarf, just like how the Member of Parliament for Salaga South, Hon Zuwera, is dressed. That is how it is properly worn.

Mr Speaker, the maker of the Statement must know that next time, as a

woman, this is the proper way to be dressed—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I will give the floor to the Majority Chief Whip. Majority Chief Whip, why are you on your feet?

Mr Dafeamekpor: The content of a Member's speech must, as much as possible, contain parliamentary language. Mr Speaker, to refer to the maker of the Statement, that as a woman, she ought to know that that is not how women are supposed to dress in *fugu*, and that the way Hajia Laadi appears is how women are supposed to properly appear in *fugu*, is improper.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, what do you have to say to that?

Mr Dafeamekpor: There is no formula for determining how a woman should appear in this House. Please, do not do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, what is wrong is wrong. No matter where it is coming from. Let us accept it and move forward.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip's interpretation of what I said is completely out of context. I said that traditionally, what Hon Laadi is wearing is how women dress in the *fugu* attire.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Habib, you are right. But so long as you said, as a woman. I mean, you know it is

offensive and once it is offensive, you only have to do the needful.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided. Let me continue to make my point.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Please just withdraw that and proceed.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, it is withdrawn. But, I am making this statement to also give out a form of education on tradition. When I make such statements, it is definitely not to insult her in any way. I am saying, traditionally, women dress like Hon Zuwera and Hon Laadi. That was the point I was making. So, I will continue to make my point.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I get the sense in the matter that the First Deputy Minority wants to convey. He can say that in his tradition, then he is situating his statement in context because traditions vary. There are women from some parts of the North who wear the *batakari* with shorts, and that is their tradition. So, he should situate it in his tradition. Then he is clear to go. But if he says, traditionally, he is mixing all the traditions, and they are not the same.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I am guided.

Wearing *fugu* signifies authority, respect and cultural identity. How the *fugu* is worn also varies from tribe to tribe. The way my good Friend, Hon Gomado, is dressed. A Dagomba like me

cannot dress the way he is dressed because we do not wear the same colour, smock and hat. It is definitely allowed. Other tribes, like the Gonjas, dress the same way he is dressed.

Mr Speaker, wearing a smock with a hat also signifies authority. Traditionally, if one wears a hat tilted to the left or right, it signifies influence and wealth. It also means someone who is peaceful. If one wears the hat with it tilted to their occiput, it signifies that no one will be able to defeat them. And when one wears the hat standing straight forward, it signifies power and authority. Traditionally, as Dagombas, only someone with the status of the Yaa Naa, the overlord of Dagbon, wears the hat with the hat pointed straight.

Mr Speaker, while the President's call is in the right direction, we should be able to identify the basics and a few small things we can signify. I took my time and was very mindful in this education because, when our President wore it in Zambia, people thought otherwise.

4:20 p.m.

They were thinking he was either wearing a parachute or he was wearing something else. So that is why I think we should be able to educate ourselves as Ghanaians, or as people from the Northern Region, where this smock traditionally starts from.

So, Mr Speaker, without saying much, I will also just commend the maker of the Statement and call on the

Hon Majority Chief Whip that if he wants to obey the directive of the President, then he must obey it properly. And when he is obeying the directives of the President that we should wear it on Wednesday, it must be complete. We must not wear it and then say that it is from the Volta Region, while others from the Volta Region are wearing it with hats. Even Mr Speaker sometimes wears it with the hats. The First Deputy Speaker understands the Dagbon tradition well. His good friend is the Yaa Naa, the Chief of Smocks. So, when he dresses, we see that he is properly dressed, and it brings out the tradition. It brings out —*[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, I would not be distracted. Without much, I support the maker of the Statement, and I think we should obey it and always try to wear it on Wednesdays. But probably after we have passed a lot of things, then we will be able to appreciate that this signifies and brings us out as Northerners.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is good to wear made-in-Ghana clothes; *fugu*, for that matter.

Hon Members, there is no single traditional way of wearing *fugu*. Some can wear the *fugu* or *batakari* with two or three “inners”. Some will just wear it without the “inner”. Some believe that with the hat, if you turn it to your left, it means you are not married and available. And some also believe that when you turn it to the right, it means you are married and not available. So, these

things do not have a single meaning or a way of wearing the smock. It is also not automatic that once you are in a smock, you have to wear the hat. It depends on the way you want to dress.

On this note, I would want to thank the maker of the Statement that every Wednesday, we must do well to be in *fugu*.

Hon Members, it is true, if an Ewe is dressed in cloth, you have to wear a shirt we call a *jumper*. But when the Ashantis are wearing cloth, they do not wear the *jumper*. So, there is no single traditional way of wearing the cloth. It varies from one place to another. And if we watch closely, when the Rt Hon Speaker wants to dress in cloth in the Ewe way, you will see him wearing a *jumper* before the cloth. When he wants to go the Ashanti way, you would realise that he would not wear the *jumper*, he would just wear the cloth. So, it varies from one area to another.

I thank the maker of the Statement, and we must make it a habit that on every Wednesday, we all appear in our smocks in order to promote the made in Ghana wear.

Hon Members, Statement time has ended.

We then move to the item numbered 7, Question time. The first Question is standing in the name of Hon Yao Gomado, Member of Parliament for Akan Constituency. We will ask the Hon Minister for Roads and Highways to take the designated seat.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF ROADS AND HIGHWAYS

Commencement of Work in Kadjebi District

Mr Yao Gomado (NDC — Akan): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when work will commence on the following areas in the Kadjebi District, since the Feeder Department completed the survey and mapping years ago: (i) Dodi-Papase to Dodo-Pepesu (ii) Dodo-Amanfrom to Daapa Junction (iii) Asato to Wawaso (iv) Koto-Nkwanta to Titiaka (v) Koto-Nkwanta to Sabram.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker,

- i. Dodi Papase – Dodo Pepesu (15.3km)
- ii. Dodo Amanfrom – Dapaa Junction (3.4km)
- iii. Asato – Wawaso (12.0km)
- iv. Koto Nkwanta – Titiaka (3.5km)
- v. Koto Nkwanta – Sabram (3.4km)

Background

The above feeder roads are engineered gravel roads in poor surface condition. The roads are located in the Kadjebi District of the Oti Region.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the roads.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates have been carried out on the roads, and the necessary interventions will be undertaken, subject to the availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any supplementary?

Mr Gomado: Mr Speaker, I have no further questions for the Hon Minister.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a constituency-specific question. We move to the Question numbered 453, also standing in the name of Hon Yao Gomado, Member of Parliament for Akan.

Timeline for the Repair of Some Roads

Mr Yao Gomado (NDC — Akan): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the following roads will be fixed: (i) Dodo – Olobi to Okrakrom (Koru) (ii) Akposokodzi Township, Kadjebi road.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

(i) Dodo – Olobi to Okrakrom road

Background

The Dodo – Olobi - Okrakrom road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads database as Olobobi Inc. - Olobobi feeder road which is 5.6km long. It is an access road located in the Kadjebi District of the Oti Region. It is

an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the road.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road to determine the appropriate interventions for consideration upon the availability of funds.

(ii) Akposokodzi Township Kadjebi road

Background

The Akposokodzi – Kadjebi Township roads are 11.6km long. The township roads are located in the Kadjebi District of the Oti Region. 3km of the town roads are bituminous surfaced in fair condition and 8.6km is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

There is no programme on the town roads.

Future Programme

Engineering studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the town roads to determine the appropriate interventions for consideration upon the availability of funds.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary?

Mr Gomado: No, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is also constituency-specific. We move to the Question numbered 380, standing in the name of Maxwell Kwame Lukutor.

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Mr Speaker, I would rather rely on Order 90(2) to withdraw this Question. This Question was asked far back in June last year, and between now and then, a lot of water has passed under the bridge. So, I would rather congratulate —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, Question accordingly withdrawn.

We move to the Question numbered 381, also standing in the name of Maxwell Kwame, Lukutor.

Ing Surv Maxwell Kwame Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I still rely on Order 90(2) to withdraw the same Question because a lot of work has been done on the road already.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This Question is withdrawn.

We move to the Question numbered 476, standing in the name of Mr Kwabena Boateng, Member of Parliament for Ejisu.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

Current State of the Ejisu-Onwe-Assieninpong-Kwaso

Mr Kwabena Boateng (NPP — Ejisu): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways the current state of the Ejisu-Onwe-Assieninpong-Kwaso road in the Ejisu Constituency and when work will resume to complete the road.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker,

4:30 p.m.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker,

Background

The Ejisu-Onwe-Assieninpong-Kwaso road forms part of the regional road R104 which starts from Ejisu and terminates at Dadease through Kokofu. This is the main road connecting Ejisu to Bekwai. The road is in poor condition. The Ejisu-Onwe-Assieninpong-Kwaso road was awarded under the contract titled “Strengthening of Ejisu - Kuntense - Bekwai Road (Km 0.00 - 22.0) and Improvement to Critical Access roads (Km 5.89)”. The contract was awarded on 29th October, 2024 for completion by 28th October, 2026. The overall progress of works is estimated at 11 per cent physical completion. The contractor is currently not on site, and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works. Mr Speaker, it is interesting to know that the financial progress on this project is 25.9 per cent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, any supplementary question?

Mr K. Boateng: Mr Speaker, there will be none, except to reiterate the plight of the people. Mr Speaker, presently cars are not plying the road anymore, passengers are stranded, pregnant women are unable to use the road and the agony of the people is unimaginable.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, your point is well noted. We move to Question number 512 standing in the name of Hon Shirley Kyei, Member of Parliament for Atwima Nwabiagya South. You have the floor.

Completion of Maakro – Agogo-Twedie & Maakro – Agogo-Twedie roads

Ms Shirley Kyei (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction of the following abandoned roads will be resumed and completed (i) Maakro – Agogo-Twedie (ii) Supreme Saviour – Canaan.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): Mr Speaker, the Maakro-Agogo-Twedie road is a 5.2 km unengineered road connecting the Maakro, Agogo and Twedie communities in the Atwima Nwabiagya Municipality. It starts from the Abuakwa-Nkawie road and ends on the Twedie-Trabuom road. Supreme Saviour-Canaan Road is a 5.5km bypass route to Abuakwa from Supreme Saviour JHS near Yaa Asantewaa Girls SHS in

Kumasi. The route traverses mostly residential properties and schools with two (2) stream crossing points.

There is currently no programme for the following roads under DUR:

- i) Maakro-Agogo-Twedie Road
- ii) Supreme Saviour-Canaan Road

Future Programme: Engineering studies and cost estimates have been carried out on the roads for consideration upon the availability of funds.

Ms Kyei: Yes, in the Hon Minister's response, he said that there are no programmes ongoing currently on the Maakro-Agogo-Twedie Road. However, in the 2024 Auditor-General's Report, paragraph 1913, lists rehabilitation of Maakro area roads as one of the abandoned projects, with this particular one projected and was expected to be completed by 5th May, 2020. It has been abandoned due to delay in the payment of Interim Payment Certificates (IPCs). How does the Ministry reconcile this Auditor-General's Report with the current response the Minister gave me?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, my Hon Colleague quoted sections of the 2024 Auditor-General's Report. I am answering the Question in 2026, and I am saying that there are no programmes currently ongoing on that section of roads. Perhaps the contracts have been terminated and we need to repackage this for a new approach. That is why I said there is currently no programme on this.

Both the 2024 Auditor-General's Report and my response are not the same.

Ms Kyei: The Report recommended that all abandoned projects should be completed before new ones are awarded. So, if mine is part of that abandoned project, can the Hon Minister, please, let me know if he is repackaging for a re-award? If so, how soon does he intend to do it?

Mr Agbodza: Yes, the Hon Member is right. The directive principles of state policy suggest that as far as possible, new governments should continue and complete projects they inherited. Indeed, President Mahama's Government has adhered to this part of the Constitution more than any government. Unlike 2017, as I said, when Government decided to have a policy to suspend almost all road projects claiming they were doing auditing, in 2025, President Mahama never asked us to suspend any project. Indeed, all contractors have been encouraged to continue working. As I said here, and I continue to say, in 2025 alone, President Mahama Government has paid contractors almost GHC10 billion for contracts he inherited. Almost all these contracts were awarded before he came. So, he is the only President in our recent history who is adhering to this portion of the Constitution. Indeed, the roads in the Hon Member's Constituency are dear to her, and I agree. As long as we continue to raise the necessary revenues, the Hon Member will also be completed in due course.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Ms Kyei: Hon Minister, can I have timelines, please?

Mr Agbodza: Yes. The timelines will be when Parliament allocates enough resources to cover the cost of completing all roads in the country. That will be done.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, let us move to Question number 516, also standing in the name of Shirley Kyei, Member of Parliament for Atwima Nwabiagya South. Hon Member, you have the floor.

Resumption and Completion of Bosankro & Akuapim Junction Roads

Ms Shirley Kyei (NPP — Atwima Nwabiagya South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction of the following abandoned roads will be resumed and completed: (i) Bosankro Junction – Bosankro (ii) Akuapim Junction – Akuapim.

Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Govers Agbodza) (MP): The Bosankro Junction – Bosankro road is a 3.5 km access road in the Atwima Nwabiagya Municipal of the Ashanti Region. It is an unengineered gravel road in poor surface condition. Currently, there is no programme on the road.

Future Programme: Engineering design studies and cost estimates will be carried out on the road for consideration upon the availability of funds.

The Akuapim Junction-Akuapim Road is a 1.1 km access road in the Atwima Nwabiagya Municipal of the Ashanti Region. It is a partially engineered gravel road in poor surface condition. There is no programme on the road. Engineering design studies have been carried out on the road for consideration upon the availability of funds.

Ms Kyei: The Hon Minister said there are designs for the road. Can he please give me when the schedule will begin and costing will be done for the road to be started?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, what I said was engineering design studies have been carried out on the road for consideration upon availability of funds. What it means is that we have carried out the engineering design. It means we can generate a cost when funds become available for us to carry out the work. Currently, we can actually tell you how much it will cost to do the project, but the reason we are not starting yet is because we do not have a budget line for it.

Ms Kyei: Does the Minister have any emergency maintenance interventions to address the poor surface conditions these roads are in?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: This should have been a full Question, not a supplementary question. But I will give the Hon Member a benefit of the doubt.

Yes, Hon Minister?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, we carry out annual maintenance programmes across our networks and all the agencies. We are currently going through that process.

4:40 p.m.

I am not sure about the particular intervention on the road she is talking about, but we are currently carrying out maintenance work on the most deplorable sections of the network. I do not have the answer here, but I can speak to her after this session on what we are doing in terms of maintenance of those roads.

Return of Contractor for Community 9 Light Industrial Area Road Network to Site

Mr Charles Forson (NPP — Tema Central): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the contractor for the Community 9 Light Industrial Area Road network will return to site.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the current programme on the road mentioned by my Hon Colleague is as follows.

Background

The Tema Community 9 Light Industrial Area Road network lies within the Tema Municipality in the Greater Accra Region. The Industrial Area Roads within the community are approximately 4.13km long, connecting the Hospital Road to the Harbour Road.

Some of the roads traverse the Cemetery to Tsopoli Estate.

Current Programme

The Community 9 Light Industrial Area Road network has been awarded for rehabilitation under the contract 'Rehabilitation of Community 9 Industrial Area Roads'. The contract commenced on 28th July, 2018, for completion by 27th July, 2020, which has since elapsed. Physical progress stands at 21.81 per cent.

The contractor is not on site due to delayed payment. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete all outstanding works.

Mr Forson: The Minister is part of Tema Central, and he is a good person. I wish to know if there is any timeline because 90 per cent of the work has already been done. I think it is left with less than 10 per cent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, he said you are part of Tema Central. As to whether that is a question—he says 90 per cent of the road—The only thing that I can call you to answer is whether there is a timeline.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, my answer is very simple, that the project started in 2018 for completion in 2020. This project should have been completed in 2020. The fact that it has not been completed by now and the work done is just 21 per cent, as far as I am concerned, it means the contractor is incapable of carrying out this work. This qualifies to

be one of the projects we will terminate and get a more qualified and more competent contractor to do. I will work with my Colleague to see what we can do to improve that road.

Resumption of Construction work on Wiosu-Amanchia, Nkawie-Nkran Foase and Ntabanum Junction to Ntabanum Roads

Ms Shirley Kyei (NPP — Atwina Nwabiagya South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Roads and Highways when the construction works will resume on the following roads: (i) Wiosu – Amanchia (ii) Nkawie – Nkran Foase (iii) Ntabanum Junction – Ntabanum.

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, the current programme on the Wiosu – Amanchia road is as follows.

Background

The Wioso – Amanchia road forms part of the regional road R108 which starts from Wioso and joins R105 at Brofuyedru.

Current Programme

The Wioso – Amanchia road was awarded under the contract titled “Rehabilitation of Wioso - Moseaso (19.50km) and Critical Accesses (5.0km)”.

The contract was awarded on 28th June, 2024 for completion by 29th June, 2026.

The Contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay

in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Nkawie-Nkran Foase road

Background

The Nkawie-Nkran-Foase road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads database as Nkawie Kuma-Nkran-Foase feeder road which is 17km long. It is an Inter-District feeder road that connects Atwima Nwabiagya Municipal to Atwima Kwanwoma District of the Ashanti region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Nkawie Kuma-Nkran-Foase feeder road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Nkawie Kuma-Nkran-Foase Feeder Road (17km)”.

The contract commenced on 10th December, 2020 for completion by 9th June, 2022 and was later revised to 5th November, 2023. The overall progress of works is estimated at 10 per cent physical completion. The Contractor is currently not on site and works have stalled due to delay in payment for work done. Efforts are being made to get the Contractor back to site to complete the outstanding works.

Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum Road

Background

The Ntabanum Junction-Ntabanum Road is captured in the Department of Feeder Roads database as Ntabanu

Junction-Ntabanu Road which is a 12 km access road on the Kumasi-Sunyani Highway. It is located in the Atwima Nwabiagya Municipal of the Ashanti Region. It is an engineered gravel road in poor surface condition.

Current Programme

The Ntabanu Junction-Ntabanu feeder road was awarded under the contract titled “Upgrading of Ntabanu Junction-Ntabanu Feeder Road (12km)”.

The contract was awarded on 23rd December, 2024 for completion by 10th August, 2026. Due to force majeure, the Contractor was unable to mobilise to site as expected. The Contractor is currently mobilising to site after warning letters were issued.

Ms Kyei: For the Wiosu-Amanchia road and the Nkawie-Nkran Foase, the Hon Minister cited delay in payment for the work done for the reason the contractor has abandoned site. I would like to know when the last payment was made and how much remains outstanding.

Mr Agodza: Mr Speaker, the contract sum is GH¢29 million Nkawie-Nkran Foase road. Works certified is just GH¢2.6 million. Mr Speaker, if a project is GH¢29 million and a person works for only GH¢2 million, and now because GH¢2 million was not paid and he stops work, it presupposes that contractor does not have the capacity to work. This is because that is too small an amount to spend on a project and stop work. He has not even done much of the work.

So, Mr Speaker, I can give her the details of the contractor. The first contractor is called Messrs Nata Construction Limited, and then the second one is also Messrs Kofi Job Construction Limited. For this particular one, the contract sum is GH¢307,888,461.46. The physical progress is just 6 per cent and there is no record of a certificate being raised for this job. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Ms Kyei: What steps is the Ministry taking to ensure that these contractors actually stick to their contractual obligations and go back to site?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, we regularly do periodic updates of the project portfolios of the various contractors, and whenever they are falling behind schedule, we draw their attention. If they fail to heed to verbal warnings, we write to them officially.

But, Mr Speaker, the truth is that majority of road contractors suspended work prior to 2024 election, more than 90 per cent, simply because they raised certificates in excess of GH¢40 billion and they were not being paid. That is why I said that it is a very good reason for President Mahama to have tried to pay almost GH¢10 billion out of that GH¢40 billion, which has never happened before. Hopefully, this should encourage other contractors who are yet to be paid to go back to site and continue to work while we find resources to pay the rest.

So, it is unfortunate that contractors risk, take loans and do projects, and are compelled to be servicing loans and

cannot tell when their certificates are going to be paid. It is a very difficult one for them. Despite this, Mr Speaker, many contractors still risk and continue to be on site, at least to make the terrible sections motorable for the public.

4:50 p.m.

We appreciate those contractors. We would continue to work to make sure that we pay the bills we owe them so that these projects are completed for the benefit of our people.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member?

Ms Kyei: Hon Minister, has the Ministry considered terminating and re-awarding these contracts if the contractor fails to remobilise?

Mr Agbodza: Mr Speaker, I always terminate projects based on the provisions in the contract to avoid judgement debt. So, there are steps we need to take to be able to make sure that they are acting lawfully within every contract. So, whenever we exhaust all those provisions in the contract, the obvious thing is to terminate.

I cannot unilaterally terminate a contract if it is obviously an affront to the provisions of the specific contract.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, this is a constituency specific Question and Question time has ended. I would use the opportunity to thank the Minister for appearing before the House.

Ms Kyei: Mr Speaker, please—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You have exhausted your supplementary questions. Please I counted; you have asked three supplementary questions and Question time has ended. Hon Minister, thank you very much for attending upon the House and responding to your Questions

Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor; Mr Speaker, we want to take the Business listed under the item numbered 13. But before that, I would want to pray you to lay two Committee Reports, that is, the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs. It is the item numbered 8 (c)(iii).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, at the commencement of Public Business, Presentation of Papers, the item numbered—Yes?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: We are not opposed to the laying of those Papers, except to remind my good Friend that, we have Businesses scheduled that have been on the *Order Paper* for a very long time.

I am just bringing it to his notice. For instance, the item numbered 9. It has been on the *Order Paper* for a very long time. The item 13 which is the House Committee Report, and the item numbered 12. He is the Chair of this Committee. Members are interested in—*[Interruption]*—No, but you see, it has been lying on the *Order Paper* for a very

long time. Mr Rockson, I do not know what you would say to that. Because if we are not ready to take these Businesses—I am not a litigant.

Mr Speaker, my concern is that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: In this case, he is not even applying to vary the order of Business. He is going in a chronological order. So, wait, when it gets to that item and he is varying the Business, then you have a cause to complain. We move from five, then to six, seven and we are now at eight.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I take a cue.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, as indicated at the commencement of Public Business, Presentation of Papers, the item numbered 8(a)—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I seek your leave to pray that the Vice Chairperson of the Committee lays these Papers, because the Chairman is unavoidably absent.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 8(a), stands in the name of the Minister of State, Government Communications.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we pray the Minister for Roads and Highways to do this on behalf of the Minister of State, Government Communications. I know that my Brother, Mr Annoh-Dompreh is not opposed to it at all.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I am not opposed, but I would ask you some questions. When he set me up against the Minister for Roads and Highways, he did not want my road to be constructed—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: As a Member of Parliament, there is a procedure to follow in asking a Member a Question.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He must do that.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The Question must first be admitted.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Where is a Minister of State in charge of Government Communications? Where is he? He is a Member of Parliament. Where is he? In mounting his application, he should be telling the Speaker where the Minister is? We do not have any problem with the Minister for Roads and Highways. He should not turn me against the Minister for Roads and Highways. Tell us where the Minister is.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker I indicated that there was an emergency Cabinet meeting today. They just finished —*[Interruption]*. He asked for further and better particulars which I am trying to provide but they would not let me—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Mr Ahmed Shaib, what you are doing is not done. When you stand up, you need to catch the eye of the Speaker before you begin to talk.

Mr Dafeamekpor Mr Speaker, the Government is preparing a major response to the cocoa issues. So, an emergency Cabinet meeting was held. The Minister for Finance will be briefing the nation shortly. Some communication would have to be prepared in that regard.

So, the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications is not here as a result of that. They asked for better particulars and I am providing it—We pray that the Minister for Roads and Highways will do this on his behalf.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Jerry Ahmed?

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, we are not opposed to the application, save that, we have to make it very clear to the Majority Chief Whip that there are very solid Cabinet Ministers sitting in this Chamber. They have never taken Parliamentary tasks for granted. They are ever present, ever faithful and ever supportive.

He is always borrowing Ministers to come and lay Papers on behalf of other Ministers. Are they not Cabinet Ministers? And they are even talking about cocoa when we know that the Chief Executive Officer takes a new chair, covered by plastic to go into the cocoa farm. Is that the way they intend to resolve the cocoa issues? We are minded and not opposed.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister for Roads and Highways?

PAPERS

By the Minister for Roads and Highways (Mr Kwame Governs Agbodza) on behalf of the Minister of State, Government Communications —

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Right to Information Commission for the Year 2024.

Referred to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 8(b), by the Chairman of the Committee.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the item numbered 8(b) is not ready. So, I pray that we go to item number 8(c) (iii).

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

The item numbered 8 (c), by the Chairman of the Committee.

By the Chairperson of the Committee —

(a) Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the Intestate Succession Bill, 2025.

(b) Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that we take the item numbered 13, I so pray.

5:00 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, this is the right time for me.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, this is the right time. I agree with you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I thank you for your guidance. So, Mr Speaker, not to belabour the point, we just exhausted or executed Business under item number 8. Reasonably, we should be proceeding to item number 9, then 10 and so on. We are jumping all the way to item number 13. Now, item number 9 is a very important Business. As we all know, Parliament has spent a lot of resources on this project. The Majority Chief Whip and I know the Report is ready. The Committee Report is ready. Why is he leaving it out? Then when we proceed to 13, the Committee chaired by him, ably assisted by my humble self, then we are done. The Report is ready. Why are we not taking this Business but jumping all the way to item number 13? Of course, we are going to do item number 13, Consideration Stage of the Legal Education Reform Bill. Why is he leaving the items numbered 9, 10 and 13?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, in respect of the business listed at item number 9, there is some consultation to be had before we take the Report. So, the Chairperson of that Committee, Hon Collins Dauda, gave me the indication that we could do this on Friday. Then in

respect of my own Committee's Report, we have indicated that we will take this on Friday as well.

Mr Speaker, these are the reasons the items numbered 9 and 12 will be taken on Friday. In respect of the items numbered 10 and 11, my indications are that those Reports are not ready. As soon as they are ready, we will lay them and then we can take them. But that will be done.

Mr Speaker, the items numbered 9 and 12 will be taken on Friday. Item numbers 10 and 11, as soon as the Reports are done, I am sure it will be before the close of the week, we will take them.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Majority Chief Whip is my Friend. I know him very well. In fact, for the past 20 years, many people do not know this. I have known him at the university. He sat by me a while ago. He just thought on his feet; I know him very well. Because as his Vice Chairperson, in respect of item number 12, he is telling me we are going to take the item on Friday, he sat by me a while ago yet he did not tell me. What wrong have I done to him?

Mr Speaker, can you imagine as a Vice Chairperson, I am not aware that the Business will be taken on Friday.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I advise you as the Whips to settle it out of the Chamber.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, yes but I need to tell him in the face.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You should resolve it out of the Chamber.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He is not treating me well.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: The item numbered 13.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, yes, but what about item number 9? I am a member of the Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, he indicated clearly that there must be some consultations. Hon Members, let us bear in mind that establishment of pension scheme for Members of Parliament goes beyond just moving a Motion. This is the first time ever we are going to establish a pension scheme for Members of Parliament. This has been non-existent. They sent people to countries who are adopting it. They came back with their Reports. Actually, because of what is involved in the establishment of this particular pension scheme, deep consultation must be carried out.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I will yield to him but the item number 13. I know there was a meeting on winnowing. I could not attend.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, so if you come to that item, I have some explanation to give to Members. Yes, item number 13.

Hon Members, while item number 13, Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025 is at Consideration Stage. I want to bring it

to the fore that I referred this particular Bill to the Winnowing Committee having regard to the numerous amendments that were filed by the Committee as well as the Members of the House and I urged Members of the House to join the Winnowing Committee to fine-tune the Bill and report to the House.

Hon Members, they did justice to the amendments, caused all to be integrated into the Bill, and this is the refined Bill that we have that if the House indulges, we will have to consider at the Consideration Stage in order to truncate making those amendments that the Committee has worked on one after the other. So, this is the Bill that will have to be distributed to Hon Members so that if you have any amendment, you just oppose the amendment within what the Winnowing Committee has worked on so that we can make a quick progress with the Bill. So, if a Hon Member does not have a copy, please, I would want to take 10 minutes' suspension to enable the copy of the refined Bill to be distributed to Members so that we come back to do the Consideration of the Bill.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, that is in order.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Most grateful. The House is suspended for 10 minutes. So, Clerks-at-the-Table, distribute copies to Members.

5:09 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

5:35 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN THE CHAIR]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, kindly resume your seats, and welcome back from suspension.

Hon Members, the Consideration Stage of a Bill is very important. During the suspension, two concerns were raised. The first one is that some Members do not have the refined Bill. The second concern is that they just got the refined Bill, so it would be proper for us to discontinue the Consideration of the Bill today so that we can do so tomorrow to enable Members to take a critical look at the work of the Winnowing Committee. Those who do not have a copy would also take a copy, and then we can do justice to the Bill tomorrow.

Hon Members, are you agreeable to this? [**Some Hon Members:** Yes.] Such being the case, we would temporarily suspend the Consideration of the Bill.

Marshal, come and do justice, and then let us take other Businesses if any.

Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have not done five hours and I move that in the absence of any further Business, the House be adjourned till tomorrow, 2:00 p.m., so that we can come back and do Business. I so move.

Mr First Deputy Speaker:
Available Leader.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to act on behalf of Leadership. This is less than a 24-hour exercise of Leadership and I do not take it for granted. So, without much ado, I second the Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, though the Motion for adjournment has been seconded, you are still going to work 24 hours. In the sense that the Bill is a bit voluminous, the Winnowing Committee has done a very good job. Please, use the rest of the period within the 24 hours, read through the Bill, and make your notes so that we can have a smooth Consideration of the Bill. Those who do not have copies should wait; the Clerks-at-the-Table will make copies available for you. More copies would be made available for you so that we all use the work of the Winnowing Committee to facilitate the consideration of the Bill.

Hon Members, the Motion for adjournment has been moved and seconded. It is for the consideration of the House.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 5:39 p.m. till Thursday, 12th February, 2026 at 2:00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was corrected by the House on 18th February, 2026.

Column 11, last paragraph, “Chief” was deleted from “Deputy Minority Chief Whip” and “First” was inserted to read “First Deputy Minority Whip”.